

Specialty database directories

Sometimes a specialty database will be more effective at finding what you need than a general search engine. A massive amount of information is not easily or entirely searchable or accessible via search tools. Specialty databases are dedicated to collecting relevant sites for a particular subject from a wide variety of business, government, humanities, legal, news, and science databases. For example, Achoo.com collects health and medical sites. Beaucoup.com lists more than 1,200 engines, directories and indices from around the world. At Search.com you can search more than 100 specialised databases. If you can't find it at any of the sites above, try Internets.com, which is another comprehensive specialty database directory.

Pinpointing people

For finding basic information such as postal addresses, phone numbers and e-mail addresses, there are a number of 'people finders' that might be helpful. Some people finders are essentially huge phone books, while others might specialise in e-mail addresses and home page URLs. Some of the best known are Switchboard, Four11, and Who Where? You might consider listing yourself, just in case someone else needs to search for you in the future. A site called Whitepages.com can help you track a person, his/her business, e-mail address and phone number. If these don't work for you, try unconventional ways like searching for a name on Usenet, or alumni sites, search engines and domain names. The search functions in ICQ, MSN, or Yahoo! Messenger might be useful in tracking down a Net-friendly person.

Business.com offers news, research, and contacts for 10,000 public companies and 44,000 private companies

Locating businesses

With the Internet, you can gather a tremendous amount of business intelligence on prospects, competitors, vendors, suppliers, and customers in just a few hours. Not only does the Net serve as a giant yellow pages for businesses, you can locate high level company information, find sales prospects and learn about an industry. To find press releases and company announcements, biz.yahoo.com/industry/ and PR newswire are valuable resources.

Bigbook.com and Worldpages.com act as giant yellow pages for international businesses—you can search for businesses closer to home with Tata yellow pages at Tpyponline.com and Getitindia.com.

Sometimes the best place to seek information on a company is their corporate Web site. You can find annual reports, press releases, and information about products and services. If you want to dig deeper, try searching through online newspapers. Scan the main page for the terms 'Archives', 'Search' or 'Back Issues' to research past articles. Sites like Newspaperlinks.com provide links to thousands of newspapers worldwide. Try and find a local newspaper located in the vicinity of the company, and scan the archives or back issues to research past articles.

Power resources

Everything2.com is man's attempt to create a 'Hitchhikers Guide to the Galaxy'. Started by the same people who created Slashdot—the news for nerds site—Everything2 works like a user written encyclopedia, with nodes on everything from rock bands to particle physics. Do not forget to check out

A Desperate Night with a Project Report

It's one of those long desperate nights where you have to finish a term paper in eight hours. Here are a few pointers on turning an unmitigated disaster of a class paper to a passable one.

- Take shortcuts. Instead of reading the entire book read the review! Reviews, abridged versions, movies are good quick substitutes.
- The Internet makes it very easy to present your viewpoint with statistics.
- Use quotations and references. Bartlett's Familiar Quotations is an encyclopaedia of quotes that you can use for any topic.
- Search for Online Writing Labs (OWL) on the Net. These are put up by colleges to help students learn the elements in writing. OWL covers almost every conceivable aspect of writing, from grammar and punctuation to choosing a title for your paper.
- Why walk the path when someone has already mapped it down? Download term papers from Schoolsucks.com! Check out the student essay network, the evil house of cheat, and A1termpaper.com.

giant online encyclopedias like Britannica.com (an updated version of the prestigious Encyclopedia Britannica), Nupedia.com, and H2g2.com.

To satisfy your scientific curiosity, check out guides at Howstuffworks.com. If you want to know anything and everything about the Net and computers, you'll find the answers at Whatis.com.

And if you're looking for insights, opinions, or help on an extremely niche topic, say, walkthroughs for a particular stage in *Diablo*, check out Allexperts.com, a site where experts share their extensive knowledge. You can ask questions on any topic, from philosophy to trivia.

So now that you are armed with the insider's tips on how to haul out the information you are looking for in the murky depths of the Internet, get out your gear and go fishing!

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What You Must Do for a Rich Haul

- Enter as many precise search terms or phrases as possible in order to limit the search. The biggest problem is noise, that is, irrelevant or inconsequential sites among the jewels.
- Enter singular terms. Most search engines will find the substring and return rivers for river. To generalise a subject, use wildcards where allowed (surg* for surgery, surgeries, surgical).
- Do not use common, generic search

terms, or if you must, include them in a phrase with more specific terms. The term 'book' would be far too generic unless it's part of a phrase like 'book binding' or 'bookseller'.

■ Enter multiple spellings where appropriate: rationalize, rationalise. If you know the correct spelling, use synonyms to broaden an ineffective search.

■ Use Booleans, especially proximity operators, to increase the relevance of your hits.